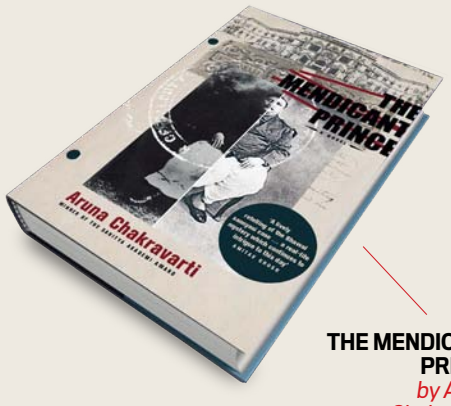




THE MENDICANT PRINCE
by Aruna Chakravarti
PICADOR INDIA
₹**599; 296** pages

BOOKS

FIT FOR A PRINCE?

After two trials, as many non-fiction accounts, several movies and at least one TV serial, the legendary Bhawal imposter case gets the novel it deserves

In January 1921, a bedraggled mendicant showed up in Bhawal, a zamindari estate now in Bangladesh. The town was agog—this man looked a lot like Ramendra Narayan Roy, a prince who had died in 1909 from a serious, if mysterious, ailment while convalescing in Darjeeling. The new arrival was presented to the aristocratic family, who, upon closer inspection, came to be convinced this was indeed "mejo kumar", or the long-dead Ramendra Narayan. At first, the stranger denied he was the prince, but soon enough, he changed his stand. He could not only recall specific incidents, names and people, but he also spoke of memories an imposter could never have known. But there was one significant sceptic. Bibhavati, his young widow, refused to meet, let alone accept this man claiming to be her husband. Given that ownership and inheritance issues were at stake, matters snowballed. The contesting claims landed in court.

The Bhawal case, as it has since been known, hogged column inches in local Bengali dailies. It captivated a kingdom, stirred passions and intersected with a growing anti-colonial movement in undivided Bengal. *A Princely Impostor?*, the definitive and deftly pieced together nonfiction account of the saga by social scientist Partha Chatterjee, examined the case both legally and historically. In *The Mendicant Prince*, the story has now got novelistic treatment at the hands of Sahitya Akademi Award winner Aruna Chakravarti, who draws extensively from Chatterjee's work, as she notes in her acknowledgements. While he examined this case against the backdrop of British India and the brewing nationalist ferment, she is concerned more with psychology rather than sociology.

ARUNA CHAKRAVARTI teases possibilities and probabilities, but never steers off-course into total fancy

Her retelling unfolds through a melange of voices and tries to untangle the competing motivations and ambiguities baked into this saga. Different chapters are narrated from different perspectives—we hear from the widow, the sisters and a sister-in-law, alongside documents and interludes from a third-person narrator. The suspense is built skilfully as we move from that fateful Darjeeling trip where he "died" and may or may not have been cremated, to a hodgepodge of doubts and contradictions.

An older sister dismisses the "imposter", then comes around to accepting him. Doctors and experts provide conflicting testimonies. And the wife stands obdurate in her rejection of this man.

The story is custom-built for drama—it features mistresses, amnesia, arsenic, a sinister brother-in-law, a long and contentious courtroom drama, rumours of incest and a merry band of Naga sadhus.

Chakravarti's historical fiction stays in its lane—she teases possibilities and probabilities, without ever steering off-course into total fancy. The facts of the case undergird the novel. Though one key chapter is written from the point of view of the lower court judge who delivers the first verdict, few other men hold narrative reigns. It's a write-around, as journalists would call it, a profile of the prince without ever inhabiting the voice of the prince. This feels appropriate both for the intrigue—is he or isn't he?—and for the fidelity to the source material. A compelling novel that does service to a compelling saga. ■

-Bhavya Dore